



The Custodian is running madly around the Wordworking Lab, robes flapping behind him and picking up prickly leaves. You approach him, and he stops, doubled over and panting as he catches his breath.



“Oh, thank goodness you’re here! The new batch of words has gotten out again, and I can’t seem to chase them all down fast enough. They never *seem* naughty when they arrive, but they never miss a chance to run off in some new direction. The thing is, if they wander too far from their origins, they’ll lose their meaning - and *then* what will become of them, I hate to imagine!”



The Custodian pauses for a moment and then seems to remember something.

“But of course, you’re new here! Perhaps you didn’t know that words had *origins*, just like the rest of us - histories and all that? Yes, well, there’s a study of those histories, and it’s called **etymology**. Look here, you don’t have to be an expert, but perhaps you could help a little? See, **we can’t start our courses without our words in order.**”



“If you can just help me **match the words out here to their histories** - even if you have to guess! - we can keep them from **dissolving into incoherence**. Hmm? Oh, right - incoherence, from the Latin ‘in’ meaning ‘not’ and ‘cohaerens’ meaning ‘sticking together. It means - oh, it means they’ll fall apart without you! Just **work together to put the words and their origins close together - close enough to touch a little**, you see? - and they’ll be just fine.”

emphatic

From a Greek word meaning "show" or "indicate"

obdurate

From a two-part Latin word meaning "hard" and "in opposition/against"

marigold

Of Middle English origin with religious context, referring to the sacred Virgin.

roguish

Of 16th-century English origin, meaning "dishonest" or "mischievous"

waif

From an old French word for "stray" or "unclaimed", with Scandinavian roots meaning "waving"

catechism

From a Greek root meaning "to instruct"

patriarchal

From a compound Greek word meaning "clan" and "command" or "rule"

birch

From Old English, from the Proto-Germanic root *birkijō*,



Etymology Escape!